

Apple files for new patent

Apple has filed an application with U.S. Patent & Trademark for an optical stylus pen patent



Android wins battle of patents

The case against Oracle's claims that Google had trampled on its intellectual property rights to the Java programming.

Sony Xperia S

We're surprised this didn't come with Android ICS



Specifications

Platform: Android 2.3;
Processor: Qualcomm MSM8260 Snapdragon 1.5GHz dual core, 1GB RAM;
Display: 4.3-inch LED, 1280 x 720 pixels; **Storage:** 32GB on board; **Camera:** 12MP with 1080p videos; **Battery:** 1750mAh

Contact

Sony Ericsson India
Phone: 1800-111-800
Website: www.sonyericsson.com
Price: ₹32,549

8.0/10

Features 7.0
 Performance 7.0
 Build Quality 9.0
 Value for Money 9.0

The Xperia S has a very premium build quality. It feels worth the price, and at no point of time do its looks betray its cost – in other words, its looks match the price point. The transparent strip running below the display is the only break from the darkness of the piano black glass. Labeled on this transparent strip are the three icons – return, home and options. However, the actual keys are the touch-sensitive ones just above the strip, indicated by three tiny dots. Compare either side of this glass; it's like the city of Liverpool divided by the Mersey River – completely different from the other. While the show-stealer is the dark shiny bit around the display, the rubberised finish below it adds a contrasting dimension. Also, this rubberised finish goes all the way around to the back – helping with the grip. Sony hasn't given the Xperia S the unibody design goodness, which means that the rear panel can be opened to access the micro SIM slot. However, the battery is locked away from user access.

If you look very carefully into the transparent strip, you'll notice a diagonal grid running through almost the entire length of the strip. Sony says that this is a part of the antenna system on the device.

Sony has clearly decided not to be a part of the quad-core processor wave, perhaps focusing more on functionality than anything else. This one comes with a dual-core processor, and on paper, that is a bit weak for a flagship device.

But performance is stable for the most part, and will improve once Android is updated.

The Xperia's 4.3-inch display has a 720p resolution. Immediately, compare it to any AMOLED display and you'll notice that while the colours don't jump out at you, they're a lot more natural. Black levels are quite deep, but AMOLED again has a slight advantage. However, gradation is a bit of an issue that you'll see with most images where colours are in bands. Apart from that, the sharpness of the display is impressive. Text looks very crisp and readable, and there is no edge noise problem when you zoom in to text. While the display is natively quite bright, we were a bit perplexed to find that there's no automatic brightness setting.

The build quality is brilliant overall, with a definite premium feel to it. Fits well in the hand, despite multiple curves and flat areas converging on one front. The transparent strip silently brings in a bit of illumination to an otherwise dark "yet another phone" design.

Timescape UI will get a major overhaul with ICS, but the current one is workable to the extent that it gets the job done without inspiring any visual goodness. Compared to the HTC Sense, Timescape feels very boxy, limited in widget range and just a bit drab. Hopefully, the new one will give you a completely different experience.

The 12MP camera on the Xperia S is a bit of a mixed bag. First off, the hardware key will take you straight to the camera,

even if the phone is locked. We don't think that the camera is very well placed. It's too far towards the top, and when you're holding the phone in landscape mode, chances are you'll have to reposition your fingers against what they'd naturally do. Image quality is a case of two very distinct halves. If you're using this to take shots in daylight, the 12MP clicker will be a delight to use for the most part – detailed shots, with a dollop of crispness and good colour depth. However, zoom in on an object and you have a problem – the clarity is severely compromised by noise. For night shots, you'll have to factor in severe shutter lag, and zooming in makes Image Stabilization less effective.

Can take 3D panorama shots as well, just like most Alpha NEX cameras do. Videos are clear for the most part during daytime, but do suffer from a bit of judder, and video stabilisation isn't very effective, even at literally no zoom. In night videos, you'll get a whole lot of noise and the zooming effect isn't very smooth either.

With a standard usage pattern, the Xperia S battery will last you a bit more than a day. With the inevitable ICS update, expect this to improve very slightly.

Sony really needs to push the ICS updates out of the door, very quickly. The Xperia S seems to have everything in place – good hardware, excellent build quality and design and a very good display. However, the UI needs to be sorted. But with the ICS update inevitable, this is a pretty decent device to buy.

Vishal Mathur